computers; and it was cold, which would be good for the air-conditioning required to keep the servers happy. It also had a fairly good free-speech tradition and, just before the banking bubble burst, was rated equal first with Luxembourg and Norway on Reporters Sans Frontières' Press Freedom Index. Iceland also appealed to my sense of humour: like a bizarre parody of a tax haven, it was far from the Caribbean, an icy island in the North Atlantic. I mentioned to the conference that all of these things made it possible that Iceland could be the world's greatest openness haven and a natural home for publishers.

I was at the conference with Daniel Domscheit-Berg and a number of people from the Iceland Digital Freedom Society. A group of parliamentarians turned up, including a woman called Birgitta Jónsdóttir, who was smart and friendly. She seemed immediately part of the spirit of our group and was interested in the idea of the openness haven. She had been elected to parliament in early 2008, and immediately on meeting her I spotted her for a potential ally. She could work for our idea of a safe haven through parliament and help us develop it in the current climate. She was a long-term activist, a poet involved with music, about forty-two, and from a famous family of Icelandic troubadours.

The seed had been planted and it grew in the minds of the conference attendees and other supporters in Iceland. The end of 2009 was a busy time for me, and I returned to Berlin to speak once more at the Chaos Communication Congress on 27 December, but I was keen to return to Iceland as soon as possible. By 5 January 2010, we were back again, still filled with the idea that we could help create this haven. There were about thirteen of us working on this – Rop Gonggrijp, Jacob Applebaum, Daniel Domscheit-Berg, Smári McCarthy, Kristinn Hrafnsson, Birgitta, and other journalists, activists and academics who offered us their advice and expertise online from the UK, Netherlands, Belgium, Germany, Hong Kong and the United States. The work meant preparing a legislative request, working from a place called the Ideas House, a sort of start-up incubator for people with ideas but no money. We worked all sorts of hours, researching, lobbying and making the thing ready so that there was a good chance it could enter into law. Birgitta Jonsdottir worked hard to drive the voting numbers to get the haven idea through parliament, and we did special presentations to some of the more conservative members. Such a landmark development was perhaps more complex than I had originally imagined,